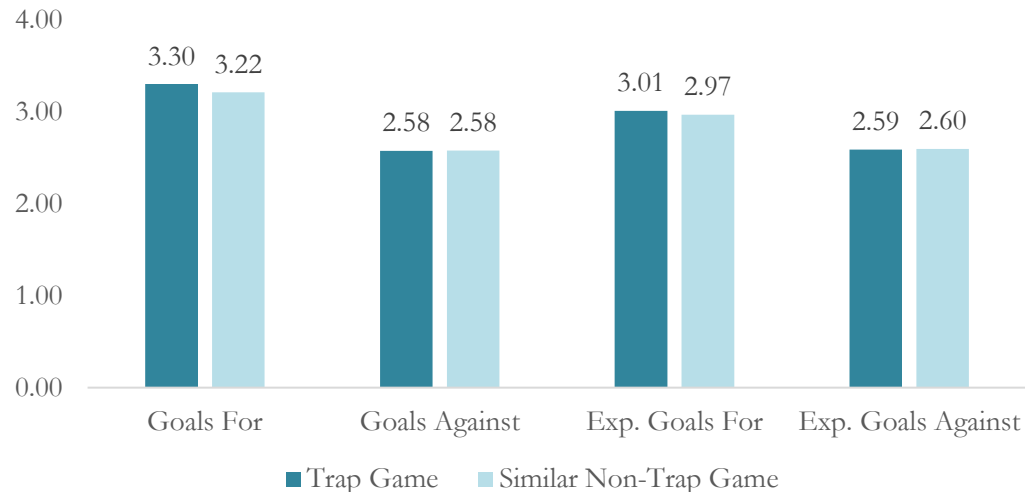


The Myth of NHL Trap Games: A Systematic Analysis

Trap Games are a popular narrative with limited systematic evidence across nearly two decades of NHL seasons.

- Most teams perform better in trap games than they do in similar non-trap games.
- Some teams underperform in trap games, however, this is not statistically significant after correcting for multiple hypothesis testing.
- Statistically significant conclusion that strong teams playing back-to-back do better in trap games than they would otherwise playing back-to-back.
- Trap games contribute minimally to multivariate models predicting game outcomes where a strong team faces a weak opponent, when controlling for other factors such as home-ice advantage, relative team strengths, and fatigue.
- Persistent narrative around trap games is a cognitive bias caused by over-fitting on memorable anecdotal upsets rather than systematic evidence.

Strong Teams Outperform in Trap Games



Trap Games Not Predictive for Strong Team vs Weak Opponent Outcomes



Source: Natural Stat Trick (2025). Covers all NHL seasons from 2007-08 to 2024-2025. See the full text and code for more details: <https://github.com/hLuo27/projects/tree/develop>